CHANGING EQUATIONS

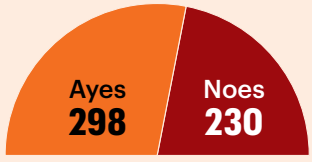
A constitutional amendment needs a two-thirds majority of members present and voting, and a majority of the total membership of each House. The NDA is better placed now than it was during the Budget session when the Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill was defeated in the Lok Sabha

LOK SABHA
Total seats: **543**

APRIL SCORE

Constitution (131st Amendment) Bill defeated

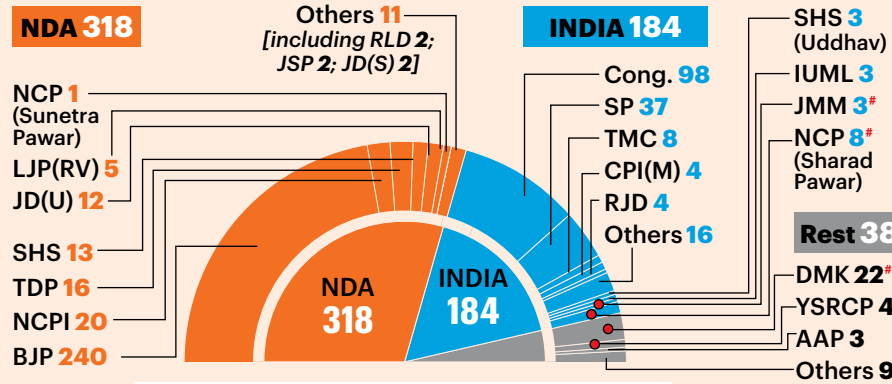
Members present: **528**



PRESENT SCENARIO

Current strength: **540** | Two-thirds majority: **360***

**of the full House; passing the bill will need two-thirds of those present and voting*



#in negotiations with the NDA govt (Total: 37)

SHS: Shiv Sena; TDP: Telugu Desam Party; NCPI: Nationalist Citizens Party of India (rebel TMC MPs); NCP: Nationalist Congress Party; LJP(RV): Lok Janshakti Party (Ram Vilas); JD(U): Janata Dal (United); JSP: JanaSena Party; RLD: Rashtriya Lok Dal; JD(S): Janata Dal (Secular); Cong.: Congress; SP: Samajwadi Party; TMC: Trinamool Congress; CPI(M): Communist Party of India (Marxist); RJD: Rashtriya Janata Dal; IUML: Indian Union Muslim League; JMM: Jharkhand Mukti Morcha; DMK: Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam; YSRCP: Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party; AAP: Aam Aadmi Party

Graphic by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY

four Rajya Sabha members away from Mamata Banerjee, with the Lok Sabha group merging into a formation that has signalled support for the NDA and the Upper House members joining the BJP outright. Six of Uddhav Thackeray's MPs have crossed to Eknath Shinde's Shiv Sena. Talks are on with the Sharad Pawar faction of the Nationalist Congress Party to merge its eight MPs with Sunetra Pawar's group. The Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam, now out of the INDIA (Indian National Democratic Inclusive Alliance) bloc, is a possibility on specific measures. M.K. Stalin, having lost the assembly election to Vijay's Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam, needs the cover of a national party against investigations by the new state government, and BJP managers are telling him the fresh bill will carry a 50 per cent formula inside it. The Yuvajana Sramika Rythu Congress Party, which had supported the bill in April as well, and the Jharkhand Mukti Morcha are on the same list.

It is still not enough. The NDA has 318 members in the lower house against the 360 required for a two-thirds majority. Even if every new constituent votes with the government, the tally comes to about 355. That leaves the managers five short and hunting. One technicality could help them. Article 368 requires two-thirds of those present and voting, along with a majority of the total membership of each House, which means an absence is worth almost as much as a conversion. A good deal of the negotiation now under way is not about who will vote yes but about who can be persuaded to be somewhere else that afternoon.

For Modi, this is the cleanest available way to look like himself again. One Nation, One Poll and women's reservation are the two pillars of the prime minister's constitutional agenda that the Opposition finds difficult to oppose openly, though they are divided on delimitation. If he succeeds in pushing through either, it will determine whether Modi 3.0 can deliver transformational change—or merely manage crises. At the same time, a second failure in four months, coming on the heels of the NEET capitulation, would be a serious blow to its credibility.

4. WINNING UTTAR PRADESH

Another test is one Modi cannot delegate, because it rests on the one skill he has consistently mastered: winning elections. Seven states go to the polls in 2027. Five of them—Uttar Pradesh, Gujarat, Uttarakhand, Goa and Manipur—are BJP-ruled; Punjab is held by the Aam Aadmi Party; the Congress has Himachal Pradesh. The biggest prize, by far, is UP, with 80 Lok Sabha seats and a 403-member assembly. But the state's